



Ages 11 to 14

Safe Adults, Secrets and Getting Help

How to tell a safe friendship from grooming, what to do if something feels wrong, and how to help a friend. For all students.

Before You Read

This guide talks about grooming: when someone builds a friendship with a young person to harm them.

This guide is about grooming, when someone builds trust, a friendship or a relationship with a young person so they can harm, abuse or use them. The person can be any age. Some of it might feel close to home. That's OK.

- Read it in bits, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline** is free and confidential. You can call 0800 1111 any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.

If you or someone else is in danger right now, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

Most adults in your life, online and offline, want to help you. But sometimes someone pretends to be a friend so they can hurt, trick or use a young person. They could be an adult, or someone close to your own age. This is called **grooming**.

- It can start in a game, on an app, at a club, or with someone you already know.
- It can happen to **anyone**, and the person can be any age, including someone only a bit older than you.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**, and **you won't be in trouble** for telling.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.
- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If someone has asked to **meet you**, or asked you for **photos**, tell an adult straight away.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free, any time.

What Do the Words Mean?

Grooming

When someone builds your trust and makes a connection with you to get you to do something sexual or illegal.

Trusted adult

An adult you feel safe with: a parent or carer, teacher, tutor, coach, house parent or counsellor.

Secret

Something you are told not to tell anyone. Surprises are fine. Secrets that make you feel worried are not.

CEOP

Part of the National Crime Agency, which helps keep young people safe from sexual abuse online. You can report to CEOP yourself.

Definition based on Childline. Checked September 2026.

Safe Friendship or Something Wrong?

A Safe Adult or Older Friend

- Is someone you can talk about with a trusted adult you choose: at school, in boarding or outside your family
- Talks to you in the open, not in secret
- Respects your age and says no to anything that isn't right for it
- Wants you to have other friends

- Never asks for photos of your body

Warning Signs

- Says "keep this between us" or "your parents wouldn't understand"
- Gives you gifts, money or game credit, then asks for favours
- Says they're the only one who really gets you
- Wants to move your chat to a private app
- Asks for photos, or asks to meet up
- Talks about sex, or makes you feel uncomfortable

Grooming often happens slowly, one small step at a time. **You don't have to wait until you're sure, or until it happens again, before you tell an adult.** If something feels wrong, that's enough.

Secrets That Feel Wrong

- A **surprise** is fun and ends soon, like a birthday present. A **secret** that makes you feel worried, guilty or scared is different.
- If anyone tells you to keep your friendship secret, that is a warning sign, however nice they are.
- People who groom sometimes say you'll get into trouble if you tell. **That isn't true.** Telling a trusted adult is always OK.

Gifts and Favours

- Presents from family and friends are normal. Be careful when someone you don't know well gives you gifts, money or game credit, especially if they tell you not to mention it.
- Sometimes gifts come with strings: "After everything I've done for you, you owe me." You don't owe anyone photos, secrets or favours.
- If a gift makes you feel you have to do something, tell an adult.

If It's Happening to You

What to Do

- **Don't meet up** with someone you've only met online, even if they seem kind. If you've already agreed to meet, don't go. Tell a trusted adult now. You won't be in trouble.
- **Don't send photos** of your body to anyone, even if they ask nicely, send one first, or say everyone does it.
- **Tell a trusted adult.** You won't be in trouble, even if you've already sent something or kept a secret.
- **Keep it.** Don't delete. You don't need to save or screenshot anything: an adult can help. If you need to block someone now to feel safe, do it, and tell an adult anyway.
- Don't tell the person you've told an adult.

If a Photo Has Already Been Sent

- **It is not your fault**, and you won't be in trouble for asking for help.
- Tell a trusted adult. **Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation):** helps under-18s get a nude or sexual image of themselves removed online, at childline.org.uk.
- If someone is threatening you, tell an adult straight away, or report to CEOP.

RESPOND: If You're Worried About a Friend

Friends often notice first. Here is how you can help, safely.

You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice the signs.

- Has a friend got a new older "friend" they keep secret?
- New gifts or money they can't explain? Dropping other friends?
- You don't need to be sure to do something



Engage

Talk and listen.

- "I've noticed you've been talking to someone a lot. Are you OK?"
- **If it is safe to do so**, the best ways to help are to **tell an adult**, **invite your friend to do something else**, and **check in with them later**



Support

Be there.

- "It's not your fault. I'm on your side."
- Keep including them. People who groom try to cut friends out

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Stop and think.

- **Don't message or contact the person**, or try to find out who they are
- Don't look through your friend's phone, or collect screenshots
- Don't promise to keep it a secret if someone could get hurt

Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Show them there's help.

- Tell your friend a trusted adult can help, and offer to go with them



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- Tell an adult what you've noticed, even if your friend asked you not to. **If a meeting is planned, tell them straight away**
- That isn't snitching. It's how people stay safe



Document

Adults write it down.

- The adult will make a record. You just need to tell them what you know



Telling an Adult

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with someone you trust.** Behind them is a team whose job is to make sure you get the right help.
- The adult will listen and take what you say seriously.
- They won't contact the person themselves or tell them you've spoken up. The safeguarding team makes a plan to keep you safe, and may involve the police. If you're worried about how your family will react, you can say so: the adult will think carefully about how, and whether, your family is told.
- If an adult is worried about your safety, they will share the concern with the school's safeguarding team. They will explain what happens next and involve you as much as possible in decisions about keeping you safe. They won't promise to keep it secret.
- Adults who work with young people are allowed to share information that helps keep children safe without asking your permission. They only share what is needed, and only with the people who need to know. They will tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put someone in danger, and they will listen to what you think.
- You will be kept informed and asked what you need.

If It's an Adult at School or a Club

- Grooming can be done by someone you know and like, including a coach, tutor or member of staff. **It is still wrong, and you can still tell.**
- Tell a different adult you trust. Adults at school know what to do, and the concern will go to the headteacher or the safeguarding team.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"Groomers are always strangers"	Many are people the young person already knows, or feels they know from online.
"It only happens to girls"	Boys are groomed too. It can happen to anyone.
"If I sent a photo, I'll be in trouble"	You won't be in trouble for asking for help. Adults will help you.
"They're my friend, so it can't be grooming"	Groomers work hard to feel like the best friend you've ever had.
"Telling will make it worse"	Telling a trusted adult is the best way to make it stop safely.

If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If someone online is messaging you at night, or wants to meet you at the weekend, tell the house parent on duty, even late. You don't have to wait until morning.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.



Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19)**: 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.**
- **CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency)**: ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, or worries about the way someone has been communicating with a child online. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking. If you're in danger, call 999 first.
- **Emergency**: call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Safe Adults, Secrets and Getting Help: Student Guide 31 - 11 to 14

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